

6.1 The Various Ways Of Using E-mail

Barring a few exceptions, everyone gets their mail in one of three ways: using Webmail, using IMAP on an e-mail client, or using POP3 on an e-mail client. (Let's just call an e-mail client a "mail program"; it sounds less officious).

"Webmail" refers to these: Gmail, Hotmail, Yahoo! Mail, Rediffmail, and more. In this method, you log on to a Web site with your username and password, and you're taken to a page where you can click on links to read your mail. You can click on a "Compose" or "Write" button to write a mail, then on a "Send" button to send it. All this is happening on the Web. You're using your *browser*, the same program you use to visit any other Web site; your browser could be Internet Explorer, Firefox, Opera, or something else.

A mail program refers to these: Outlook Express (it's installed on all non-Vista Windows computers), Outlook (which comes with Microsoft Office), Thunderbird (which was developed by the same group that made Firefox), and others. These are programs dedicated to the sending and receiving of mail; they are not browsers (though some do have browsing capabilities, but let that not confuse you). When you send and receive mail using these, you are not on the Web, meaning you aren't visiting a Web site. And now, there are two main "ways" you can use a mail program—IMAP and POP3.

Two sentences of explanation are needed here: when someone sends you an e-mail, it gets stored on a *mail server*. What you're doing when you use a mail program is, you're retrieving your mail from the mail server onto your personal computer, either permanently or temporarily. IMAP and POP3 happen to be the two ways (mainly) of doing that.